

Head and shoulders above: As the Black Caps' most prolific Test batter, Kane Williamson scored 9,515 runs at an average of 54.06, including 33 centuries, in 110 matches. REUTERS

white-ball moments, including one at Lord's in 2019. There was another when he returned to the format in 2023 after initially retiring, slamming England's highest individual score: 182 against New Zealand.

Teams mirroring their captains

The duo's playing styles mirrored their personalities. When captaincy arrived, their teams soon became extensions of them.

Williamson took over from Brendon McCullum in 2016 and turned New Zealand into one of the most complete sides in world cricket, competing everywhere and in every format. Under him, New Zealand reached the 2019 ODI World Cup final, won the inaugural ICC World Test Championship Final 2021, and made the 2021 ICC Men's T20 World Cup Final later that year.

There was consistency, much like Williamson himself.

Stokes' England was different. In 2022, alongside McCullum, he gave Test cricket a new language that revolved around being aggressive, fearless and exciting. It did not always bring England every result it wanted, but it changed how the format was spoken about. 'Bazball' became an identity, and Stokes lived it.

In his retirement speech during the third Test, he asked his teammates for one final effort. "We've got a lot of hard work to do, and the only thing I want is to be able to walk off that field, regardless of the result, knowing that I've had this group give everything for the last two days. That's the only thing I want, for everyone to give it not only to me, selfishly, but also to this team."

In his final outing, Stokes opened the innings, charged down the track first ball and attempted a reverse ramp the very next delivery. Simply because he could. It was chaotic and entirely on brand. He made 30 off 20



before walking back into the sunset to a standing ovation.

Not long before that, Williamson, too, had announced his departure after New Zealand's defeat in the first Test at Lord's, but quietly. Neither a grand speech nor an elaborate farewell, just a statement. "I stand here to announce my retirement from international cricket." Fittingly, Williamson.

For years, cricket had both extremes at once. In Williamson, it had its old-school charm, proof that greatness did not need spectacle. In Stokes, it had its great showman.

And as they leave together, the sport loses two men who, in completely different ways, elevated the game far beyond where they found it, all while staying completely true to who they were.

Format	M	Runs	Best	100s	50s	Avg.
Tests	110	9515	251	33	38	54.06
ODIs	175	7256	148	15	47	48.69
T20Is	M	Runs	Best	S/R	Avg.	
	93	2575	95	123.08	33.44	

Captaincy record

Format	M	W	L	D	Tied	NR
Tests	40	22	10	8	—	—
ODIs	91	46	40	—	1	4
T20Is	75	39	34	—	1	1

KANE WILLIAMSON

